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Getting Started with Zotonic

Zotonic is an open source Web framework built with Erlang. It is fast, scalable and extensible, and has been built to support dynamic, interactive websites. Marc Worrell, the main architect of Zotonic, started working on the project in 2008.

Zotonic aims to be a CMS that is as easy to use as a PHP CMS but with all the advantages inherent in the Erlang environment.

Zotonic has obviously been influenced by PHP CMSs like Wordpress, Drupal, etc. The difference is that it is written in Erlang. Its objective is to offer the performance and scalability advantages inherent in Erlang, effortlessly (<http://www.aosabook.org/en/poza/zotonic.html>). More importantly, it hopes to be a framework in which you can create a new site using existing modules and not have to write any Erlang code. Obviously, at present, the range of modules available for Zotonic dwarfs the number of modules available for the common alternatives.

Let's look at how to create two sites using virtual hosts on the same server and using the sample skeletons included in the Zotonic distribution.

Installation

Before starting, Erlang should be installed and the PostgreSQL database server should be running. Go to <http://zotonic.com/download> to get the current release. Unzip and run the Zotonic server as follows:

```
$ unzip zotonic-0.9.4.zip
$ cd zotonic
$ make
$ ./start.sh
```

Pointing a browser to *localhost:8000* will show that the Zotonic server is running. Keep the server running and add two sites.

```
First, create the two databases:
$ su - postgres
$ createuser -P zotonic
$ createdb blogdb -O zotonic
$ createdb basesitedb -O zotonic
```

Now, create the two sites:

```
$ bin/zotonic addsite -u zotonic -P <db pw> -d basesitedb
-s basesite basesite
$ bin/zotonic addsite -u zotonic -P <db pw> -d blogdb -s
blog blogsite
```

The options '-u' and '-P' specify the credentials to use for the database. The option '-d' specifies the database to be used and '-s' specifies the skeleton to be used. Basesite and blogsite are the names of the sites, and are accessible using virtual host names—the same as the site names. Add the following entries to */etc/hosts*:

```
127.0.0.1 blogsite
127.0.0.1 basesite
```

Now, browse *blogsite:8000* and *basesite:8000* and you will have two distinct sites.

Adding content

Each site has an admin module included in it. Explore the admin module by going to the url *blogsite:8000/admin*. You will see a page like the one in Figure 1.

Choose the option to 'make a new page'. You will need to give the page a title. Choose the category as 'article'. Select the 'publish' option. Now add some text and images in the form offered, and save it.

Now, if you go back to the home page, the newly added page should be the first item.

Repeat the same process with the basesite. In this case, the main content of the home page will not change. The newly added page and images will show up in the column on the right under 'Recent content'.

Structure of a site

Look in the *zotonic/priv/sites* directory and you will find the directories *basesite* and *blogsite*, which contain all the site-specific information. Each site needs a *config* file and a *<site name>.erl* file. The *config* file is an Erlang list that contains information about the site, the database and the modules to be installed. The *erl* file is essentially a minimal Erlang module.